

Apply to be a Science Corps Fellow - Entry #3350

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Non-binary
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Oakland (California), USA
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When did you or do you expect to complete your PhD?
June 2025
Please tell us briefly about your university education (institution, city, country, year)
I received my B.S. in Biology from the University of Central Arkansas in 2014, my M.S. in Geosciences from Baylor University, and will receive my Ph.D. in Integrative Biology from UC Berkeley in May 2025. During my tenure at UCA, I took an array of core science classes including foundational courses in biology, chemistry, physics, geology, geography, mathematics, and statistics, alongside many upper division courses in biology. While working toward my M.S. at Baylor, I took several upper division and graduate courses in geology and biology, followed by several more graduate courses in biology while working toward my Ph.D. at UC Berkeley. While at UC Berkeley, I had the opportunity to take a Teaching Colloquium course that reviewed best practices in pedagogy and participated in many teaching workshops.
Why would you like to be a Science Corps Fellow?
I would like to be a Science Corps Fellow because I want to help make a difference by applying my skills as a science educator and developing new skills while working with a team of educators and building community. I am passionate about and dedicated to improving scientific education and have extensive experience in teaching and communicating science to the public, along with experience editing and developing teaching materials in biology and geology. I truly enjoy finding new, interactive, and creative ways to apply and teach scientific concepts and being a Science Corps Fellow would give me the opportunity to do just that while working with a community and striving to make a difference in the field of scientific education on a global scale. Having grown up in a small rural town in Arkansas, my first exposure to evolution and geosciences was at my undergraduate institution. I was fortunate to have passionate instructors who inspired me to learn more, ask questions, and ultimately become a science educator. Many people have very little interactions with geosciences or

plant biology outside of a quick lesson in their foundational high school courses, if they're lucky. This is one of the many reasons I enjoy teaching geoscience concepts— it's a wonderful opportunity to expand knowledge on a topic the audience likely knows little about. For me, communicating science to the public is an opportunity to pass along knowledge while navigating societal barriers to make the community a well-informed and better place. Being an educator comes with responsibility, and I believe that it is of utmost importance to be respectful, truthful, fair, and passionate. As a science communicator, I emphasize that learning science is understanding how the world works and what we are learning is tied to bigger, broader concepts. I truly enjoy making the connections of structure, function, environment, and evolution, as well as getting people engaged with the environment and organisms around them. As a Science Corps fellow, I look forward to continuing and growing my science education and communication skills while working abroad.

In addition to your studies, please describe any prior experience that may help you as a Science Corps Fellow.

I have extensive teaching experience as a Graduate Student Instructor (GSI) at Baylor University and the University of California, Berkeley (UCB). I have taught biology and geology classes at the lower division, upper division, and graduate level. Teaching lab and discussion sections gave me the opportunity to learn and grow from mistakes and evaluations and through this process I found a new passion in education— being an educator. This passion for educating has grown during my time as a GSI at Baylor and UCB and I was fortunate to teach an array of biology discussions and labs while working with a diverse student body. I have been presenting my research at professional science conferences since 2013 when I presented my research at the Botanical Society of America and have had the opportunity to share my research many times at a variety of local, national, and international conferences.

In addition to communicating science as an educator and professional, I have a diverse experience communicating scientific concepts to the public through various outreach activities. While an undergraduate student at the University of Central Arkansas (UCA), I helped organize and facilitate UCA's Earth Day activity where we interacted with the public to remove invasive species from the Jewel Moore Nature Reserve and conducted a rapid-bioassessment of a creek on UCA's campus while involving undergraduate students from all departments. Following this, I volunteered for the Conway, Arkansas Eco-Fest where I talked with the public about local biodiversity showing them invertebrate and vertebrate specimens and discussing their ecological importance. During my tenure at Baylor University, I volunteered to help teach paleobotany lessons to the Waco Montessori School classes, helped teach geology-themed lessons at the Waco Wetlands to elementary students, and was part of a graduate student panel where we discussed our experiences as graduate students to Baylor undergraduates. While working toward my PhD at UCB, I taught paleontology lessons to middle school and community college classes while volunteering for Bay Area Scientists Inspiring Students (BASIS) and Advancing Community College Education and Student Success (ACCESS). I also had the opportunity to engage with the public community during a Bay Nature Bio-blitz event where I helped attendees identify local plants and fungi. I volunteered for Cal Nightlife at the California Academy of Sciences where I engaged with the public in discussing various paleobotanical specimens, highlighting their importance and relevance to plant evolution. Most recently, I was invited to virtually visit a middle-school classroom in Greers Ferry, Arkansas where I discussed my research, what a paleontologist does, and answered their questions about paleontology.

Where do you imagine yourself professionally in the future? Check all that apply.

Scientist in academia
Doing science in industry
In science education
In science outreach

Please expand on your selection above and describe where you imagine yourself professionally in the near (~2 year) and long-term (~10 year) future.

Professionally, in the next 2 years I imagine myself either in a non-profit field-based position doing botanical related fieldwork for conservation work or in an academic/research position teaching biology and botany classes. I have been applying for both types of jobs and would be happy in either setting, as long as there is an outreach component to the industry/non-profit position. Long-term, I hope to be established at either a non-profit or education position. If I'm at a non-profit, I hope to have moved up to a different position, hopefully in a manager role; if I'm teaching at an institution, I hope to have established my research lab and be under consideration for tenure.

Please upload your CV (.pdf)

 [jdwagner_CV_2025_updated.pdf](#)

How did you find out about Science Corps?

An email list in your institution

[Science Corps](#)